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Dominance and defiance

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Relation to Grandparents • Relations to Siblings and Cousins

In this regard, it is interesting to note that not only are cross-cousins differentiated significantly by shame and respect responses in our questionnaire material, but informants speak of a cultural practice of joking between cross-cousins of the opposite sex which did not appear on the questionnaire because it is usually carried on between young people rather than by mature men who formed the bulk of the sample. The joking takes the following form. A young man or boy jokes with one of his junior female cross-cousins calling her wife, concubine, lover, etc., and she returns the joke calling him slave, husband, lover. She also begs "joking money" from him on *Sala Laya* (roughly the New Year). This brings on play behavior with the younger and older siblings of the girl who are now in the position of "wife's" younger sibling (*tiu*) and "wife's" older sibling (*k[unknown]esai*). Because there is a joking relation in the "real" kinship system between a man and his wife's junior siblings (real and classificatory), this joking is extended to the junior siblings of the junior cross-cousin who is chosen as the joking wife. They, too, can ask for joking money on *Sala Laya* . Siblings older than the wife are treated jokingly as if they were senior in-laws, i.e., with respect and avoidance. The young man can change the joking wife from time to time among his junior cousins, and then re-order his joking senior and junior in-laws accordingly.

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This practice is not universal. A number of informants claimed that such behavior was unbecoming and hinted at the idea of illegitimate pre-pubescent sexual activity being a possible concomitant. Whatever its frequency, as in the case of shame responses already noted, such a practice seems out of place in a kinship system in which *all* cousins are terminologically equivalent to one

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another and to siblings, and where patrilineal parallel cousin marriage is sanctioned and preferred as well as cross-cousin marriage.

Relation to Grandparents

As Table 4:1 indicates, there is almost total agreement among respondents that a joking relationship exists between ego and his grandparents or great-grandparents if these are alive. As already noted, such relations are present when the customary restrictions based on differences of generation, seniority, and sex are relaxed and a formalized pattern of permissiveness obtains between the parties.

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Besides formal joking, a number of cultural practices unite grandparents and grandchildren. Kanuri generally give the children the names of their own parents, thus children are often linked to a particular grandparent by a namesake relationship (*chubuna*). Conversely, anyone after whom a child has been named has a joking relationship (albeit somewhat milder) with his namesake. Since there is a non-reciprocal name avoidance between children and own parents, many young Kanuri boys and girls are addressed and referred to as *Abagana* or *YaGana* (small father, or small mother). Furthermore, many children are given to relatives or friends for fostering after weaning (18 months) and a favorite fosterer is the grandparent. Informants state that it is a good thing to give children away for fostering. Some go further, explaining that very young children do not understand proper respect, especially for their father and therefore it is a good thing for them to go away and learn such behavior elsewhere. When they return, they do so as more fully socialized members of the family who can understand the proper relations between children and parents. Again, an ideal person or couple to carry out such training is said to be the grandparent. On the other hand, people say that a child being raised by grandparents should return to his or her parents before puberty because there can be no real or proper respect where there is so much joking.

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It is not uncommon to see a grandparent visiting his or her friends always accompanied by one of their little joking partners. As the friends sit down to chat, the grandchild may play nearby, then a little later comes over to nestle in the grandparent's arms. He pulls at the grandfather's beard, or grandmother's beads, and acts in a generally affectionate manner. The observer is struck more with the genuine fondness and affection of the relationship, at its early stages, than with any  47 patterned joking. However, this latter quality becomes more marked through time. The grandparent may point out a young playmate of the opposite sex and say "There is your wife, or your husband, eh?" One informant summed up neatly:

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You may pull your grandparent's beard, or go into his house and take his possessions, and he does not mind; he is happy because his children have borne children. If you have a great-grandparent alive it is the same with him.

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